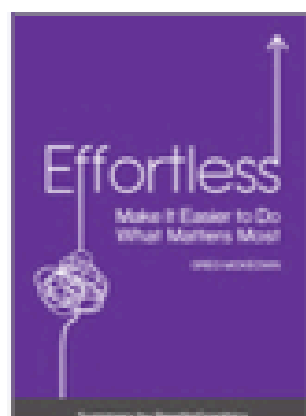




EFFORTLESS

Make It Easier to Do What Matters Most

GREG MCKEOWN



The Big "So What"

Do you sometimes feel like you're not making progress despite your best efforts? Or, do you feel so exhausted that you can't find the energy for your important tasks, or to even enjoy your successes? In his previous book, *Essentialism*, McKeown explained how to define the most essential things to focus on. In this book, he explains how to structure your work to make those essential activities also the easiest ones to achieve.

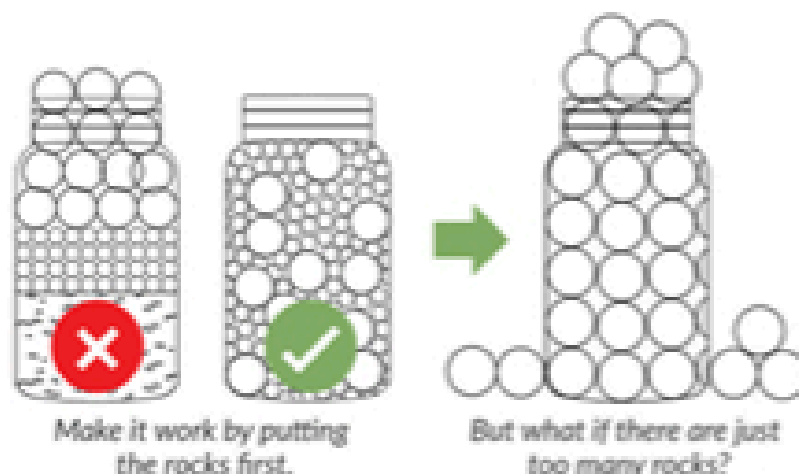


Introduction



When we feel overwhelmed, we tend to work harder. Yet, all of us have a finite amount of time and energy. You can only push yourself so far before you eventually burn out.

- This is like trying to fit a mix of rocks, pebbles and sand into a jar. The best approach is to start with the rocks (your biggest priorities), followed by the pebbles, then the sand. But, what happens if there are just too many rocks to fit into the jar? If you've already distilled down to the most essential stuff and there's still not enough time, then you need a different approach.



KEY QUOTES

"Essentialism was about doing the right things; Effortless is about doing them in the right way."

"This book may not make every hard thing easy to approach and carry, but I believe it can make many hard things easier."

"What does one do when they've stripped life down to the essentials and it's still too much?"



"Effortless" is about fundamentally changing how you work.

- Make the most essential activities the easiest to do, so you needn't push so hard to get your desired outcomes.
- In the next sections, we'll explain the 3-part Effortless approach:
 - (i) Get into the *Effortless State*, where you're relaxed and performing optimally;
 - (ii) Take *Effortless Action* to get better results with less effort; and
 - (iii) Enjoy *Effortless Results* with repeated benefits from the same effort.



Part 1: Get into The Effortless State



The brain is like a computer. It has huge computing abilities, but slows down when its capacity is maxed out. When you're tired or distracted, you cannot operate optimally and any activity seems harder and more effortful. However, after a meal and a good night's rest, you feel refreshed and everything seems easier.



The Effortless State is where you're functioning at an optimal mental, emotional, and physical condition. You feel well-rested, light, clear-headed, energized, and focused. You can operate at peak performance to finish your most essential tasks with minimal effort.



Invert: Make it Easy

When something feels impossibly difficult, look for an easier or simpler way to achieve the same outcome.



"This is so hard."



"Is there an easier way?"

KEY QUOTES

"What could happen in your life if the easy but pointless things became harder and the essential things became easier?"

"The Effortless State is one in which you are physically rested, emotionally unburdened, and mentally energized...You are able to do what matters most with ease."



Do not overcomplicate things and overwhelm yourself unnecessarily.

- Effort ≠ Value. We've been conditioned to believe that anything worthwhile requires effort, and anything effortless is bad (e.g. "taking the easy way out" or "making easy money"). That's untrue.
- In fact, our brain is designed to take the path of least effort, and we naturally resist things that seem hard. The more you overthink an issue, the more you procrastinate.



Invert your thinking to see problems from an opposite viewpoint:

- Ask if the contrary could be true. Instead of thinking "this is so hard", ask "Is there an easier way?" or "What's the simplest way to achieve this outcome?"
- Challenge the "right" way to do things. For example, Southwest Airlines was debating whether to invest in a \$2mil ticketing system to print, issue and check airline tickets. They challenged their assumptions of what an airline ticket must look like, and found a drastically cheaper and simpler solution—to just print their tickets on normal paper.
 - (i) How can you *eliminate or reduce the complexities* so a tiny effort can bring massive results?
 - (ii) Instead of fighting something head-on, can you find an *indirect approach*?



Enjoy: Make it Fun

Work and play aren't mutually exclusive. Combine or pair your most essential activities with your most enjoyable ones.



The more you enjoy something, the more you'll do it consistently or look forward to it. On the other hand, if you dread something, you'll find excuses to put it off. So ask yourself, "How can I make this more fun/enjoyable?"

KEY QUOTES

"What if the biggest thing keeping us from doing what matters is the false assumption that it has to take tremendous effort?"

"When we remove the complexity, even the slightest effort can move what matters forward."

- For example, Comic Relief combines fund-raising with comedy to make it both desirable and fun for people to give to charity. During the annual Red Nose Day, people can enjoy themselves by donning red clown noses, contributing to, and participating in fundraising activities with celebrities/ comedians.



Pair or combine essential activities with immediate rewards or something you love.

- For example, try listening to your favorite audiobook only when you're at the gym. This creates an instant reward to make exercising enjoyable in itself, rather than having to wait for months to see the results.
- Combine your essential activities with the things you love. For example, everyone in McKeown's family used to dread cleaning up after dinner—until they turned the chore into a singalong session with Disney classics blasting in the background.

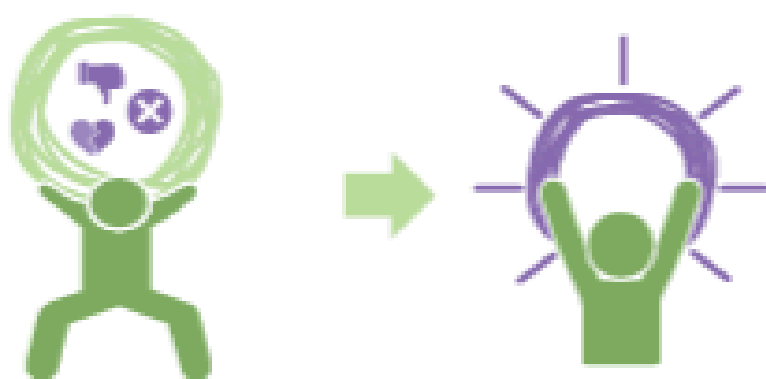


Convert essential tasks into meaningful rituals. For example, Marie Kondo advocates designating a spot for each item in your house, so you can return them home lovingly after each use, thus making tidying up a form of ritual. Form your rituals with formulas like "After I do X, I'll do Y" or "As I do X, I'll do Y."



Release: Lighten your Load

Let go of emotional burdens that weigh you down and blind you to possibilities.



Often, we unknowingly carry emotional burdens, such as old grudges and regrets, or outdated goals and principles. These take up mental-emotional space and weigh us down.

- When you encounter a setback or tragedy, it doesn't help to lament your loss or blame others. Set yourself free by

KEY QUOTES

"By pairing essential activities with enjoyable ones, we can make tackling even the most tedious and overwhelming tasks more effortless."

"Our rituals are habits we have put our thumbprint on. Our rituals are habits with a soul."

"Grudges cost us resources but don't deliver a satisfying return on our investment. So we must relieve a grudge of its duties."

"When we let go of our need to punish those who've hurt us, it's not the culprit who is freed. We are freed."

accepting what has happened, forgiving others and yourself, and letting go of your pain and grudges.



Focus on what you have, not what you lack. The more you complain about your circumstances and dwell on what you lack, the more drained you feel, which leads to a negative spiral. The more you focus on gratitude and what you have, the more you see new possibilities to start a positive spiral.



Consciously turn negativity to gratitude.

- Each time you complain, make sure you follow by saying something you're grateful for. For instance, if you hear yourself saying, "Traffic was terrible", add on "I'm grateful I made it here safely!" With time, you start to notice your complaints, reframe your perspectives habitually, and may even catch a complaint before you finish the thought or sentence.
- Use the same approach to counter negativity from others. For example, if a teammate complains about her workload for a major project, remind yourself that you're glad to be working on such a meaningful project.



Rest: Recover Fully

Tap on your body's natural rhythms and cycles by alternating between periods of exertion and renewal.



If you keep pushing yourself to work longer and harder, your performance will eventually decline, and you may burn out or hurt your health. The best-performing professionals take periodic breaks to recover on a daily, weekly and monthly basis.



Alternate between periods of exertion vs renewal.

- Tap on your body's natural 90-minute cycles. For example:

KEY QUOTES

"When you focus on what you lack, you lose what you have. When you focus on what you have, you get what you lack."

"There is an ebb and flow to life. Rhythms are in everything we do. There are times to push hard and times to rest and recuperate."

- (i) Devote your mornings to the most essential work; and
- (ii) Break down each morning into 3 x 90 minute sessions, with a 10-15 minute break between each session.

- If you're already struggling, it's counterproductive to push harder. Take a short break (even for 1 minute) to recover and resume at a higher level of performance.



Sleep is absolutely essential for peak performance and health.

- Aim for 8 hours' sleep every night. Your body needs enough quality sleep to fully restore itself. Research found that people who regularly sleep <7 hours a night are more prone to a host of health issues, such as cardiovascular diseases, strokes, diabetes and arthritis. A lack of sleep also negatively affects your creativity, alertness, and social interactions.
- You can partially offset a sleep debt by napping.
 - (i) If you feel too tired to focus, take a short nap to refresh yourself. A 90-minute nap can deliver similar learning benefits to 8 hours of sleep.
 - (ii) We often get creative ideas while we dream. Place a pencil and notepad next to you when you nap, so you can quickly capture the ideas when you wake up.



Notice: See Things Clearly

Train your mind to focus and tune out distractions, so you can be fully present to the details and information around you.



Often, we're so distracted by the noise around us that we fail to notice what's truly important. In the Effortless State, you are operating with heightened awareness, which allows you to notice complex, fast-moving details/information, zoom in on what's important, and process the information effectively.

KEY QUOTES

"Do not do more today than you can completely recover from today. Do not do more this week than you can completely recover from this week."

"Getting more sleep may be the single greatest gift we can give our bodies, our minds, and even, it turns out, our bottom lines."

"It's not the noticing itself that's hard. It's ignoring all the noise in our environment that is hard."



When you're fully present in your interactions, you can also help others to gain clarity. Listen, ask clarifying questions, and reflect back what you've heard. Don't jump in with your views or judgments, as it may put the other person on the defensive or crowd out his/her ability to see and think clearly.



Train your mind to focus with this daily practice:

- Prepare your space (2 min): Find a quiet, decluttered area, turn off your phone, and ensure you won't be disturbed for 10 min.
- Relax your body (2 min): Sit comfortably with your back straight and your eyes closed. Breathe naturally and gradually relax all parts of your body.
- Clear your mind (2 min): Notice your thoughts as they surface and allow them to pass without dwelling on them.
- Free your heart (2 min): Think of someone who wronged you, say "I forgive you," and imagine cutting the chain between you.
- Relive a moment you're grateful for. Imagine yourself breathing in the gratitude (2 min).

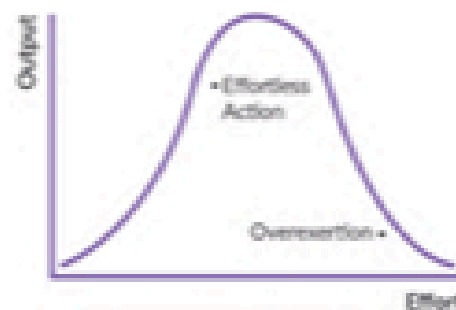


Part 2: Take Effortless Action



When we put in extra effort, it usually yields results to some extent before diminishing returns set in. This is when you start to get less output for the same amount of effort.

- Eventually, you may even get negative returns, e.g. if you get so tired that you make costly mistakes or get burned out.



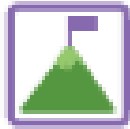
Effortless Action is about achieving more results with less effort. It occurs when you get in flow and operate "in the zone". You take action with clarity, instinctively know what to do, and deliver great results with minimal effort.

KEY QUOTES

"When we are fully present with another person, we see them more clearly. And we help them see themselves more clearly as well."

"Past a certain point, more effort doesn't produce better performance. It sabotages our performance."

"The goal is to accomplish what matters by trying less, not more."



Define What “Done” Looks Like

Define your end-goals clearly to channel your time and effort effectively. Stop when you reach the finish line.



Often, we procrastinate because we don't know what to do. Once you have a crystal-clear idea of what the finish line looks like, you feel motivated to start taking action.

- Close your eyes and take 1 minute to clearly visualize the finish line or what “done” looks like. Then, describe it in concrete terms. For example, “getting fit” could mean “I can fit into my Puma sports attire and run 5km without stopping.”



Define “done” for all aspects of your life:

- Only start on an essential task/project after defining the end-goal.
- Create a “Done for the Day List” daily. Limit this to tasks that contribute to your essential goals. You should feel satisfied if you finish all the items on the list at the end of the day.
- Define the things that to be done while you're still alive.



Start with the Obvious First Step

Identify the “minimum viable action” and take the first baby step.



To avoid getting overwhelmed, focus on identifying the “minimum viable action” toward your goal.

KEY QUOTES

KEY QUOTES

- This is similar to a minimum viable product in business, i.e. building a prototype to test a product idea. For instance, Airbnb founders started by posting a few pictures of their apartment on a webpage, just to see if anyone would pay to stay at the apartment while they were away.

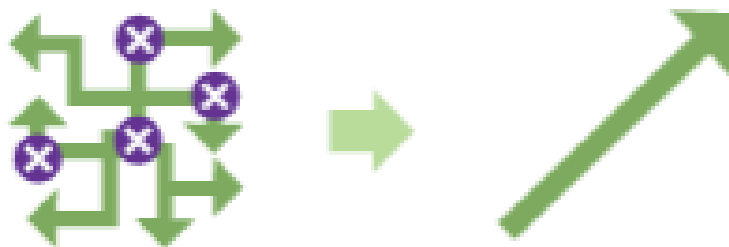


After you identify the first obvious action, break it down into the tiniest concrete step, then do 10 minutes of focused activity. For example, if you need to finish an article, the first obvious action is to get a pen/paper (or turn on your computer). Then, take 10 minutes to draft an outline. This mini burst of activity generates energy, motivation, and confidence to propel your next steps.



Simplify: Start From Zero

Start from a blank slate to define the minimum steps required for your desired results.



Don't start with a complex process then try to reduce it. Start from scratch by asking "what are the minimum steps needed to get the desired results?" Then, focus on those steps and remove all others.

- In 1998, online shopping was still very complex, and users had to fill in many fields before they could make a purchase. Amazon drastically changed the experience by creating the one-click ordering process.



Keep it simple. Don't try to go the extra mile just for the sake of doing so. For example, you don't need 50 slides to present an idea. In fact, you may not need any slides at all. It's better to complete your first step, then to aim for 10 steps and take none.

"The simplest steps are the ones you don't take."

"There is rarely a need to go that second mile beyond what's essential. It's better to go just the first mile than to not go anywhere at all."



Progress: Do a Thrashy Draft

Start with an ugly first draft, then quickly learn and improve it.



Don't try to perfect everything from the onset. Start with a raw and ugly first draft, so you can learn quickly and advance from there.

- In 1959, industrialist Henry Kremer offered a prize for the design of the first human-powered aircraft that could fly in a figure-eight around 2 markers half-a-mile apart. Many of the well-funded teams focused on developing an elegant design. The winning team (led by Paul MacCready) focused on building an aircraft they could fly and maneuver. Their design was ugly and basic, but it allowed them to run hundreds of test flights, and to rapidly repair and redesign their aircraft each time it crashed.
- The same concept applies to any new endeavor. If you're learning a new language, keep practicing with people no matter how silly you sound. If you're writing a book, just put down your first words on paper no matter how bad they seem.



At the same time, minimize the cost of your failures so you can keep experimenting. Think of yourself like a toddler learning to walk—if you fall, just get up and try again until you succeed.



Pace: Move Faster at a Steady Pace

In the long run, it's faster to set a smooth, steady pace than to start and stop repeatedly.



Many people get caught in a boom-and-bust cycle. They sprint as fast as they can toward an important goal, then stop when they run out of steam. After some time, they feel guilty and dash forward again. The start-and-stop process ends up wearing them down.

KEY QUOTES

"There is no mastery without mistakes. And there is no learning later without the courage to be rubbish."

"To make effortless progress on what matters, learning-sized mistakes must be encouraged."

"Going too fast at the beginning will almost always slow us down the rest of the way."



It's much better to set a consistent pace that you can sustain.

- In 1911, 2 groups of mountaineers set out to scale the South Pole. One group covered 15 miles a day regardless of the weather. The other group pushed hard during good weather and hunkered down on bad days. In the end, the group with the steady pace succeeded, while the other group perished.
- The key is to set an ideal range, e.g. read between 5-30 pages a day, or walk 500-10000 steps a day.
 - (i) The *lower limit* should be high enough to motivate you, but low enough to achieve even if you face unexpected obstacles.
 - (ii) The *upper limit* should be high enough to challenge you, but not so high that it exhausts you.



Part 3: Achieve Effortless Results

Linear results give you one-time benefits with a 1:1 effort-to-output ratio. For example, you get paid for each hour you work, or must remind your kids to do the same chore daily. Your results are tied to the amount of effort you put in.

Residual results deliver repeated benefits with little or no additional effort. For example, you can write a book once and earn royalties for years, or make a chore so fun that your kids do it automatically.

- Residual results allow you to achieve exponential growth. They come from applying Effortless Action to high-leverage activities.



Learn: Tap on Others' Knowledge

Residual results can come from learning universal principles that you can apply over and over again.

- Good methods or techniques can be helpful in specific situations, but you must find new methods for different situations.

KEY QUOTES

"Producing a great result is good. Producing a great result with ease is better. Producing a great result with ease again and again is best."

"With residual results you exert effort once and reap the benefits again and again."

"A method may be useful once, to solve one specific type of problem. Principles, however, can be applied broadly and repeatedly."

KEY QUOTES

- Look for universal principles that cut across different fields or scenarios. Once you grasp why something happens or how it works, you can apply the knowledge repeatedly, or even develop your own methods and strategies for different scenarios.
- For example, you might delight your spouse by cooking her favorite meatball spaghetti for dinner, but she'd get sick of it within a few days. However, if you can identify the underlying principle (to do thoughtful things that show how well you know her and how much you love her), you can delight her consistently.



The good news is, there are already established principles in many domains, from science to economics and business. The most powerful insights often come from combining existing knowledge across different fields.

- Reading is one of the best ways to learn. Prioritize books that have lasted the test of time (e.g. classics), read with the goal to understand the contents, and summarize what you've learned to internalize the ideas.
- Absorb what others already know, then combine the knowledge in your own way to create a unique breakthrough.



Lift: Leverage a Network



One of the best ways to reach the masses is to teach others to teach. For example, early in the Covid pandemic, ProjectProtect created 5 mil masks in 5 weeks to help address the severe mask shortage. They achieved this by recording a 5-minute video to teach people how to make masks, then called for volunteers to use the video and materials to teach/help others to create masks.

- When you teach others, you tend to pay more attention to details, and must understand the concepts enough to explain them in your own words. This accelerates your own learning.



Make your messages simple to understand, remember, and repeat. Create great stories that are easy to recall and share, like Aesop's Fables which have been passed on for centuries.

"Stand on the shoulders of giants and leverage the best of what they know."

"Knowledge may open the door to an opportunity, but unique knowledge produces perpetual opportunities."

"Make the most essential things the easiest ones to teach and the easiest ones to learn."

"There is no better way to teach than through the power of stories."



Automate: Do It Just Once



Our brains have a finite capacity, and we're prone to mistakes when we're tired or overwhelmed. So, never rely on your memory for essential tasks. Create checklists for your most important and complex tasks, to minimize the risks of over-taxing your brains or making avoidable errors. Once you've created your checklists or cheat sheets, you can use them repeatedly.



Automate repeatable decisions or processes, e.g. automating bill payments, pre-scheduling your annual health checkups, or setting alerts when supplies fall below a certain threshold. Make the essentials high-tech and low-effort, and the non-essentials low-tech and high-effort.



Leverage the Power of Trust



Trust is like the lubricant that keeps your interactions and relationships running smoothly with minimal friction.

- You work more quickly and effortlessly with people you trust. You can easily exchange information, discuss issues, assign tasks, and focus on getting the essential work done instead of second-guessing one another and navigating politics.
- In 2003, Warren Buffett's Berkshire Hathaway bought McLane Distribution from Wal-Mart for >\$1bil. This huge deal was closed in a 2-hour meeting, and the purchase completed in another 29 days without any due diligence. This was possible only because Buffett's past experience told him he could trust the other party. That's the power of trust.



Surround yourself with trustworthy people who can deliver the desired results reliably without constant supervision.

- Invest the time/effort to hire the right people from the onset. The wrong hires can be extremely costly as they may underperform, engage in unethical actions, and influence future hires and cultural norms.
- Build high-trust structures by setting clear goals and expectations, defining who to do what, and designing

KEY QUOTES

"As the world gets more complex, we all need tools to help us remember what's important."

"You can't have a high-performing team without high levels of trust."

"Taking a little time to build a foundation of trust is a valuable investment in any relationship."

incentives that align individual actions with the broader team/organizational goals.



Prevent Problems in Advance



Often, we're so busy fighting fires that we don't stop to find a more lasting solution.

- Don't just manage the symptoms. Find and tackle the root cause to resolve the issue once and for all. For example, instead of using medication to control your heart condition, fundamentally improve your health by changing your lifestyle and diet. Focus on problems that (i) generate the highest cumulative cost or irritation, and (ii) can be resolved quickly. For instance, it only takes a few minutes to lubricate the rails of your drawer so it doesn't get stuck each time you open it.
- You can also take preventive measures, e.g. setting up an alarm system to flag out warning signs. The earlier you identify the problem, the more likely you can resolve it successfully. For example, hospitals use machines to track patients' vital signs, with a list of triggers and warning signals to look out for.



Check your assumptions and data to avoid costly, preventable mistakes. For example, France's state-owned railway company SNCF purchased 2000 new trains, only to realize that they couldn't fit into a quarter of the train stations. It turned out they had used the dimensions for France's newer railway stations, not realizing that the older stations were designed with wider platforms.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book

No matter what challenges or hardships you've encountered, how you choose to respond now will decide what happens down the road. Go for the lighter and more effortless path, not the heavier and more effortful one. Don't make life harder than it has to be.

This is a clear, easy-to-read book with many examples from McKeown's own experiences, references to other books and lessons from various thought leaders. The book also includes illustrations to bring the ideas to life. For more details, please visit <https://gregmckeown.com/>.

KEY QUOTES

"Don't just manage the problem. Solve it before it happens."

"Rather than simply hacking at the branches, try striking at the root."

"Mistakes are dominoes: they have a cascading effect."

"If you take away just one message from this book, I hope it is this: life doesn't have to be as hard and complicated as we make it."